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ENC 1101

27 September 2026

How Kairos Shapes My Sense of Belonging at the RWC

Commercial gyms are close to identical, and that is the point of them. Cardio machines sit near the door, weight machines fill the middle, and free weights and squat racks go in the back. The UCF Recreation and Wellness Center follows that template almost exactly. The building is dense with equipment and almost empty of decoration. Where the walls are not glass, they are mirror. The only UCF color in the free weight area is a gold stripe and a black stripe painted across gray cinderblock, with no logo and no lettering. I have trained in this layout for years and I keep a squat rack in my garage, so I knew how to read the room the first time I walked in.

Doug Downs calls a space like this a rhetorical ecology, “a network of myriad interconnecting and almost inseparable elements” (466). The RWC has a lot of rhetors, and most of them never say anything. UCF set the policies. The architects put the least intimidating equipment in sight of the door. Student workers enforce the rules, and the few signs are short: wipe your machine down, re-rack your weights. The users are rhetors too. Every person who re-racks a plate, or leaves one out, tells the next person what the norms are. One element in this ecology is out of everyone’s hands, and that is time. My class schedule decides when I am free, and the other students decide how crowded the floor is. At the RWC, my sense of belonging depends on the hour I walk in, because the same building that makes room for me in the early morning crowds me out at 10:45 a.m. on a Tuesday without changing a single object in it.

On a normal morning the building is quiet. The only sounds are treadmill belts, a plate being set down, and short exchanges between two people. Every rack in the free weight area is open, so I move straight down my plan without waiting for anything. The quiet tells me that everyone there came to finish a task and leave, which is what I came to do too. I get my full three exercises per muscle group, and I leave feeling like the session belonged to me. At that hour there is room for me, and the pace of the floor matches mine.

Tuesday at about 10:45 a.m. is the one hour in my week when I cannot train early. By then the RWC is packed and loud, with constant movement between stations and conversation layered over the equipment noise. This week I went in for chest, back, and shoulders. After my first exercise the plan stopped working, because the next machine I needed was occupied, and so was the one after that. I spent the session walking the floor looking for whatever was open and building my workout around other people. I run on a schedule, so improvising annoys me. I did two exercises per muscle group instead of three, and I left early because I did not want to keep waiting. I felt like I was in the way and like other people were in mine. I am still a paying UCF student with the same access to the same building, so my right to be there had not changed. What changed was whether the space could hold me.

Downs gives the ancient Greek term for this. Kairos, he writes, “translates to something like ‘timely good fortune’ or simply ‘lucky timing’” (467). He explains that the people in a rhetorical situation never have full control over it, because events outside their control can change the moment and what makes sense to do in it (467). That describes my Tuesday. The racks, the mirrors, and the signs were the same as the morning before. The only thing that changed was how many people were in the room, and I had no say in that. Kairos explains why

my belonging at the RWC rises and falls with the clock, even though my student ID gets me in at any hour.

Work Cited

Downs, Doug. "Rhetoric: Making Sense of Human Interaction and Meaning-Making." *Writing about Writing*, edited by Elizabeth Wardle and Doug Downs, 3rd ed., Bedford/St. Martin's, 2017, pp. 458–481.